

Writing in the Humanities

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HIGH SCHOOL AND COLLEGE WRITING

Some students make very smooth transitions from writing in high school to writing at the College, and we heartily wish all of you an easy passage. But other first-year students are puzzled and frustrated by their experiences in writing for the College Core. Only months earlier your writing was winning praise; now your instructors are dissatisfied, saying that the writing isn't quite "there" yet, saying that the writing is "lacking something." You haven't changed—your writing is still mechanically sound, your descriptions are accurate, you're saying smart things. But they're still not happy. Some of the criticism is easy to understand: it's easy to predict that standards at college are going to be higher than in high school. But it is not just a matter of higher standards: Often, what your instructors are asking of you is not just something *better* but something *different*. If that's the case, then you won't succeed merely by being more intelligent or more skillful at doing what you did in high school. Instead, you'll need to direct your skills and your intelligence to a new task.

We should note here that the College is a big place and that you'll be asked to use writing to fulfill different tasks. You'll find occasions where you'll succeed by summarizing a reading accurately and showing that you understand it. There may be times when you're invited to use writing to react to a reading, to speculate about it. Far more often—like every other week—you will be asked to *analyze* the reading, to make a worthwhile *claim* about it that is not obvious (*state a thesis* means almost the same thing), to support your claim with good reasons, all in four or five pages that are organized to present an *argument*. (If you did that in high school, write your teachers a letter of gratitude.)

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ARGUMENTS AND THEIR USES

Now by "argument" we do not mean a dispute over a loud stereo. In the College, an argument is something less contentious and more systematic. It is a set of statements coherently arranged to offer three things that experienced readers expect in essays that they judge to be thoughtful:

- They expect to see a *claim* that would encourage them to say, "That's interesting. I'd like to know more."
- They expect to see *evidence, reasons* for your claim, evidence that would encourage them to agree with your claim, or at least to think it plausible.
- They expect to see that you've thought about *limits and objections* to your claim. Almost by definition, an interesting claim is one that can be reasonably challenged. Readers look for answers to questions like "But what about . . . ?" and "Have you considered . . . ?"

This kind of argument is less like disagreeable wrangling and more like an amiable and lively conversation with someone whom you respect and who respects you; someone who is interested in what you have to say, but will not agree with your claims just because you state them; someone who wants to hear your reasons for believing your claims and also wants to hear answers to her questions.

At this point, some students ask why they should be required to *convince* anyone of anything. "After all," they say, "we are entitled to our opinions, so all we should have to do is tell you what they are. You decide whether you want to agree." This point of view both misunderstands the nature of argument and ignores its greatest value.

It is true that we are all entitled to our opinions and that we have no duty to defend them. But this University has always held as its highest value not just the pursuit of new knowledge and better understanding, but the sharing of that knowledge. We write not only to state what we think but also to show why others might agree with it and why it matters. We also know that whatever it is we think, it is never the entire truth. Our conclusions are partial, incomplete, and always subject to challenge. So we write that others can test our reasoning. To do that, we present our best thinking as a series of claims, reasons, and responses to imagined challenges, so that readers can see not only what we think, but whether they ought to agree.

And that's all an argument is—not wrangling, but a serious and focused conversation among people who are intensely interested in getting to the bottom of things *cooperatively*.

Those values are also an integral part of your education in the

College. For the next four years, you will be asked to read, do research, gather data, analyze it, think about it, and then communicate it to readers in a form in which enables them to assess it and to use it. You will be asked to do this not because we expect you all to become professional scholars (though proportionally more of you will than will students from any other American college or university) but because in just about any profession you pursue you will do research, think about what you find, make decisions about complex matters, and then explain those decisions—usually in writing—to others who have a stake in your decisions being sound ones. In an age of information, what most professionals do is research, think, and make arguments. (And part of the value of doing your own thinking and writing is that it makes you much better at evaluating the thinking and writing of others.)

In the next few pages, we're going to walk you through a process of creating an argument in a Humanities or Social Science Core paper. Note that we're describing "a" process and not "the" process. We're not describing the way that everyone does go about writing an argument. We're certainly not describing the way everyone must go about writing an argument. Further, we can't cover everything, and some of your teachers will expect something other than what we describe here. There are even some differences between how you write papers in Humanities and in the Social Sciences. But within all these limits, we can lay some groundwork for writing College papers.

We begin with the assignment that gets you started; then we discuss some ways to plan your paper so that you don't waste too much time on false starts. We conclude with some strategies for drafting and revising, especially revising, because the most productive work on a paper begins after you have gotten your ideas out of the warm and cozy incubator of your own mind and into the cold light of day.

ASSIGNMENTS

Not all of your instructors will be equally clear about what they expect of your paper. Some will tell you in detail what to read, how to think about it, and how to organize your paper, but others will ask a general question just to see what you can do with it. Some instructors will expect you to stay close to the assignment, penalizing you if you depart from it; others will encourage you to strike out on your own. A few instructors may want you to demonstrate only that you have read and understood a reading, but most will want you to use your understanding of the reading as a jumping-off point for an analysis and an argument.

So your first step in writing an assigned paper occurs well before you begin writing: You must know what your instructor expects. Start by assuming that, unless you see the words "Summarize or paraphrase what author X says about subject Y," your instructor is unlikely to want just a summary. Beyond this point, however, you have to become a kind of

anthropologist, reading the culture of your particular class to understand what is said, what is not, and what is intended.

Start by looking carefully at the words of the assignment. If it is phrased in any of these ways, one crucial part of your task has been done for you:

- "Agree or disagree: 'Freud misunderstood the feminine mind when he wrote . . .'"
- "Was Lear justified in castigating Cordelia when she refused to . . .?"
- "Discuss whether Socrates adequately answered the charge that he corrupted the youth of Athens."

For questions like these, you start (but it's only a start) by considering two opposing claims: Freud understood the feminine mind or did not; Lear was or was not justified, Socrates did or did not answer the charges against him. For reasons we will discuss below, you will *not* want the claim of your paper to be merely yes or no, he did or he didn't. But an assignment like this can make it easier to get started because you can immediately begin to find and assess data from your readings. You can look at passages from the reading and consider how they would support one of the claims. Remember: this is only a start. You do not want to end up with a claim that says nothing more than "Freud did (or did not) understand the feminine mind"; "Lear was (or was not) justified in castigating Cordelia"; "Socrates did (or did not) adequately answer the charge."

More likely, however, your assignments will be less specific. They won't suggest opposite claims. Instead, they'll give you a reasonably specific sense of subject matter and a reasonably specific sense of your task:

- "Illustrate," "explain," "analyze," "evaluate," "compare and contrast . . ."
- "Discuss the role that the honor plays in *The Odyssey*."
- "Show how Molière exploits comic patterns in a scene from *Tartuffe*."

None of these assignments implies a main point or claim that you can directly import into your paper. You can't just claim that "honor does play a role in *The Odyssey*" or that "Molière does exploit comic patterns in *Tartuffe*." After all, if the instructor has asked you to discuss *how* Molière used comic patterns, she presumably already believes that he *did* use them. You get no credit for asserting the existence of something

we already know exists.

Instead, these assignments ask you to spend four or five pages explaining the results of an analysis. Words such as "show how" and "explain" and "illustrate" do *not* ask you to summarize a reading. They ask you to show how the reading is put together, how it works. If you asked someone to show you how your computer worked, you wouldn't be satisfied if they simply summarized: "This is the keyboard, this is the monitor, this is the printer." You already know the summary—now you want to know how the thing does what it does. These assignments are similar. They ask you to identify parts of things—parts of an argument, parts of a narrative, parts of a poem—then to show how those parts fit together (or work against one another) to create some larger effect.

But in the course of so doing, you can't just grind out four or five pages of discussion, explanation, or analysis. It may seem strange, but even when you're asked to "show how" or "illustrate," you're still being asked to make an argument. You must shape and focus that discussion or analysis so that it supports a *claim* that you discovered and formulated and that all of your discussion and explanation develops and supports. We'll talk more about claims in a later section.

A third kind of assignment is simultaneously least restrictive and most intimidating. These assignments leave it up to you to decide not only what you will claim but what you will write about and even what kind of analysis you will do: "Analyze the role of a character in *The Odyssey*." That is the kind of assignment that causes many students anxiety because they must motivate their research almost entirely on their own. To meet this kind of assignment, the best advice we can give is to read with your mind open to things that puzzle you, that make you wish you understood something better.

(Now that advice may seem almost counterproductive; you may even think that being puzzled or not understanding something testifies to your intellectual failure. Yet almost everything we do in this university starts with someone being puzzled about something, someone with a vague—or specific—dissatisfaction because we do not know something that seems important or because we want to understand something better. The best place to begin thinking about any assignment is with what *you* don't understand but wish you did.)

If after all this analysis of the assignment you are still uncertain about what is expected of you, ask your instructor. If your class has a Writing Intern, ask that person. If for some reason you can't ask either, locate the Academic Tutor in your residence hall and ask that person. *Do this as soon as possible.* You're not likely to succeed on an assignment if you don't have a clear sense of what will count as success. You don't want to spend time doing something different from what you're being asked to do.

WHAT'S YOUR POINT?

However different your assignments may seem, most will share one characteristic: In each, you will almost certainly be asked to make a point. Now when we talk about the "point" of your paper, you should understand what we do and do *not* mean. If asked what the point of their paper is, most students answer with something like, "Well, I wanted to write about the way Falstaff plays the role of Prince Hal's father." But that kind of sentence names only your *topic* and an *intention* to write about it.

When most of your instructors ask what the point of your paper is, they have in mind something different: By "point" or "claim" (the words are virtually synonymous with *thesis*), they will more often mean the most important *sentence* that you wrote in your essay, a sentence that appears on the page, in black in white; words that you can point to, underline, send on a postcard; a sentence that sums up the most important thing you want to say as a result of your reading, thinking, research, and writing. In that sense, you might state the point of your paper like this: "Well, I want to show/prove/claim/argue/demonstrate [any of those words will serve to introduce the point] that

"Though Falstaff seems to play the role of Hal's father, he is, in fact, acting more like a younger brother who..."

If you include in your paper what appears after "I want to prove that..." then that's the point of your paper, the main claim that the rest of your paper supports.

BUT WHAT'S A GOOD POINT?

A question equally important to what a point is, though, is what counts as a good one. We will answer that question here, even though it gets us ahead of ourselves in describing the process of writing a paper. Many beginning writers think that writing an essay means thinking up a point or thesis and then finding evidence to support it. But few of us work that way. Most of us begin our research with a question, with a puzzle, something that we don't understand but want to, and maybe a vague sense of what an answer might look like. We hope that out of our early research to resolve that puzzle there emerges a solution to the puzzle, an idea that seems promising, but one that only more research can test. But even if more research supports that developing idea, we aren't ready to say that *that* idea is our claim or point. Instead, we start writing to see whether we can build an argument to support it, suspecting, hoping that in the act of writing we will refine that idea, maybe even change it substantially.

That's why we say we are getting ahead of ourselves in this account of writing a paper, because, as paradoxical as it may sound, you

are unlikely to know *exactly* what point you will make until *after* you have written the paper in which you made it. So for us to talk about the *quality* of a point now is to get ahead of ourselves, because we haven't even touched on how you might think about drafting your paper, much less revising it. But because everything you do at the beginning aims at finding a good point, it is useful to have a clear idea about what it is you are trying to find, what makes for a good point.

A good point or claim typically has several key characteristics: it says something significant about what you have read, something that helps you and your readers understand it better; it says something that is not obvious, something that your reader didn't already know; it is at least mildly contestable, something that no one would agree with just by reading it; it asserts something that you can plausibly support in five pages, not something that would require a book.

Measured by those criteria, these are not good points or claims:

- "I *Henry IV* by William Shakespeare is a play that raises questions about the nature of kingship and responsibility." Sounds impressive, but who would contest it? Everyone who has read the play already knows that it raises such questions.
- "*Native Son* is one of the most important stories about race relations ever written." Again, your readers probably already agree with this, and if so, why would they read an essay that supported it? Further, are you ready to provide an argument that this point is true? What evidence could you provide to make this argument? Are you prepared to compare the effect of *Native Son* with the effects of other books about race relations?
- "Socrates' argument in *The Apology* is very interesting." Right. So?
- "In this paper I discuss Thucydides' account of the Corcyrean-Corinthian debate in Book I." First, what significant thing does this point tell us about the book? Second, who would contest this, that is, who would argue that you are *not* going to discuss Thucydides' account?

None of these is a particularly significant or contestable point, and so none of them qualifies as a good one.

What does qualify as a good claim? These might:

- The three most prominent women in *Heart of Darkness* play key roles in a complex system of parallels: literally as gatekeepers of Africa, representatively as gatekeepers of darkness, and metaphorically as gatekeepers of brutality.

- While Freud argues that followers obey because each has a part of themselves invested in the leader, Blau claims that followers obey in order to avoid punishment. Both neglect the effects of external power.

You should recognize, however, that you will only rarely be able state good points like these *before* you write your first draft. Much more often, you *discover* good points at the end of the process of drafting. Writing is a way of thinking through a problem, of discovering what you want to say. So do not feel that you should begin to write only when you have a fully articulated point in mind. Instead, write to discover and to refine it.

(One note on the language of point sentences. If you're like us, you will want your readers to think that your points are terrifically interesting and significant. What almost never accomplishes this is to say: "My point is terrifically interesting and significant." Many writers try to generate a sense of importance for what they write by simply adding some synonym of the word "important": "An important question to consider . . ."; "It is essential to examine . . ."; "A crucial concern is whether. . . ." This isn't going to work. What convinces readers that a point is important is not the word "important," but the words that tell us the substance of the point. If, during your first draft, you find yourself using words like "important," you should make a note to yourself to come back during your revisions to replace "important" with more substantive language. Then don't forget to do it. It's really important.)

GATHERING EVIDENCE

Once you understand the assignment, your next task is to find data that is relevant to meeting it. The word "data" makes some humanists flinch a bit, but we need a word that distinguishes all the facts, quotations, references, numbers, and events that might be relevant to your assignment from those facts, quotations, references, and so on that might support your specific claim or point. All the information related to your assignment is data; data becomes evidence when you use it to convince readers to agree with your point.

We do not have the space here to discuss the process of reading critically and selecting data, thinking about what you have gathered, analyzing it, and discovering the point or claim that you want to make and support. Every assignment will ask you to look at your readings in a different way, and every text you read will raise its own problems of interpretation and analysis. In fact, that is what most of your classes are about: selecting and analyzing data, and arriving at a plausible conclusion about them. The essay by Jonathan Z. Smith in this collection covers much of what goes on when you think about your readings.

The best generic advice we can give is this:

- Go through your readings once and mark with a highlighter *everything* you think plausibly relevant to answering the assignment.
- So that you can get a sense of it all, go through a second time, skimming what you have highlighted.
- Go through a third time, marking passages that seem *most* central to your assignment. Try to assign to each passage a key word that will help you sort them later.
- Now try to categorize those passages according to how they might support different points: which ones support one point, which support another point. (Spend the time it takes to find data that might support different, even opposing, points. You need such data so that you can critically balance one point against another.)
- On a piece of paper, jot down what you think are the central concepts that emerge from this analysis.
- To these central concepts attach subsidiary concepts. Use some sort of symbol to represent the kinds of relationships that the subsidiary concepts have to the central concepts and to one another: cause and effect, similarity, contrast, more important/less important, earlier/later in time, and so on. Spend time playing with these relationships. Make lists of the central concepts, order and reorder them, find categories and subcategories.
- Then create a working outline around topics suggested by your categories of evidence.

At this point, you may have a fairly clear idea about the point you want to make; more often, you won't. Either way, if you have even a dim idea about the shape of your general point, prepare to start your first draft.

PLANNING YOUR FIRST DRAFT

You may have been told in high school that you needed a detailed outline before you began to draft a paper. For some writers that's good advice; for others it is not. Some writers can't begin writing until they have a detailed outline consisting of their main point and every subpoint, in the order in which they intend to make them. Other writers need an outline of some kind, but usually only of topics so that they know what the parts of their paper are and the order in which they want them to appear. You will know which is right for you only after you

write a few papers.

But almost everyone profits from at least a scratch outline, which focuses your attention on particular aspects of your paper in a particular order:

- Harlem Renaissance—art using experience to develop urban identity.
- African-American art muffled in rural south.
- Migration north: transforming effect of urban life.
- Armstrong transforms mainstream song using folk and African elements.
- Significance of opposition to jazz.
- Motley transforms painting with bold color, form and subject (stereotypes?).
- Clash of “dignified” vs. “primitive.”

If you can formulate a complete sentence that captures the central idea in each section, so much the better. But it is likely that you will discover those sentences in the act of drafting, as well.

BEGINNING YOUR FIRST DRAFT

Every writer, novice or expert, feels at least some small twinge of anxiety when it comes time to write the first sentence of a paper. That's why some writing teachers tell you to write your introduction last. What they mean, of course, is that after you finish a draft, you need to go back and rewrite your introduction. Once you know what you've said in the draft, you can write a much better introduction to it. So in that sense, you will have written the real introduction only after you've written the draft: you'll have written the introduction last. But even first drafts need introductions of some kind, so none of us escape that moment of uncertainty.

It is useful to spend more than a moment or two thinking about even this first draft introduction because it has a way of so entrenching itself in your paper that you will have a hard time getting rid of it when you get to your last draft. You may be resolved to get rid of your first draft introduction later, but such a resolution can fade as your deadline approaches—especially when sunrise is approaching at the same time. It is not a bad idea even from the beginning to take some steps to avoid last minute trouble.

First, here are some introductory strategies to *avoid* even in first drafts. If they survive into your last draft, you can be sure that your instructor will judge them amateurish.

- Don't simply echo the language of the assignment. If the assignment says, “Discuss the logical structure of the Declaration of Independence, particularly those assumptions

on which Jefferson based his argument,” do not start with something like, “In the Declaration of Independence, Jefferson based his argument on assumptions that are part of its logical structure.” You're very likely to need some of the language from the assignment, but you should leave room, even in your first draft, for language of your own.

- Don't offer a history of your thinking about the assignment. Don't begin, “In analyzing the logical structure of the Declaration of Independence, it is first necessary to define the assumptions that Jefferson worked with. In my analysis, I found that Jefferson began with one assumption, which was that. . . .”
- Don't begin with “Webster's defines *x* as. . . .” That is not only amateurish; it is useless. Any word important enough to define in a paper is too complex to be adequately defined in a dictionary.
- Don't begin with grandly banal statements: “The Declaration of Independence is the greatest and most logical document in American history. . . .”

How should a *working* introduction begin? One way to focus your own thinking is to begin with a kind of sentence that you must change in the final draft:

I am addressing the issue of [fill in your topic here] in order to show why/how/what/who/whether [fill this in with subject and verb].

For example:

I am addressing the issue of *the relationship between Jefferson's assumptions and evidence* in order to show *how he depended on assumptions that he could not prove but needed in order to use the evidence he had*.

That kind of sentence focuses your attention not on what you are writing *about*, but on what you are trying to *do*. The indirect question such as “show *how*” or “explain *why*” helps you identify something that you do not know but are trying to find out.

If you have even a tentative answer to your question, state it at the end of your introduction. That will launch you into the body of your paper with some sense of direction. If you do not have a tentative answer, make up some sentence that uses most of the key terms you came up with when you were assembling, organizing, and analyzing your data. Not sure how to fit those key words into a sentence? Feel free to use question marks, ellipses or just blank space to reflect your uncertainty: “The grounds that Jefferson most relies on are specific acts

of tyranny (injustice?), which caused him to rely on unproven assumptions . . . fundamental purpose of government." You can come back to this sentence after you've written the draft to fill in the missing pieces.)

If you can get some key terms into your introduction, you will help yourself focus on developing those concepts.

AFTER YOUR INTRODUCTION

Your biggest risk at this point is that immediately after you end the introduction, instead of laying down the foundation of your argument, you fall into a long narrative summary of what you have read. This summary can actually be a valuable part of your writing process, but only if you have started your paper at least three or four days before it is due and if you will substantially revise what you have written. In these circumstances, your summary is a useful way of gaining control over your subject matter.

But perhaps the most common problem that first-year students have with their papers is that they take this summary of their subject, tack on a half-page conclusion and then turn the essay in. They may spend an hour or two tinkering with spelling and punctuation, but essentially, once they've written the summary, and added a short conclusion, they're done. It is a pattern of behavior that many students fall into without even noticing. Remember: if you feel you have to summarize, start drafting at least three or four days before the paper is due. Give yourself time not only to write the summary, but to transform it into an argument.

TWO STYLES OF DRAFTING

There are two extremes in drafting styles. Some writers draft as fast as they can make pen or keys move. Not worrying about style or correctness, or even clarity (least of all spelling and punctuation), they try to keep the ideas flowing. If they bog down, they note why they got stuck, refer to their outline for their next move, and push on. If they are on a roll, they do not type out quotations or footnotes: they insert just enough to know what to do later. Then if they do freeze up, they have things to do: fiddle with wording, add quotations, play with the introduction, review what they've drafted, in a sentence or two summarize the ground they have covered. As a last resort, they correct spelling, punctuation—anything that diverts their minds from what is blocking them, but keeps them on task, giving their subconscious a chance to work on the problem. Or they go for a walk.

There are others, though, who cannot work with such "sloppy" methods, but only "word-by-perfect-word," "sentence-by-polished-sentence." They cannot start a new sentence until the one they are working on is dead right. If this sounds like you, if you cannot imagine

a quicker but rougher style of drafting, do not fight it. But remember: the more you nail down each small piece, the fewer alternatives you have thereafter. For this reason, if you are a "sentence-by-sentence" drafter, you must have a detailed outline that tells you where you are going and how you will get there.

Whichever style is yours, establish a ritual for writing and follow it. Straighten up your desk, sit down, sharpen your pencils or boot up your computer, and get the light just right, knowing that you will sit there for an absolute minimum time. If you sit staring, not an idea in your head, write a summary of what you've already thought about: "*So far, I have these points. . .*" Or look at the last few paragraphs you wrote, and treat some important bit of evidence as a claim in a subordinate argument.

THE CRUCIAL PART OF WRITING: REVISION

When you have finished your first draft, you should have enough time left for a few hours of revision. Ideally, you should leave enough time to put the draft aside so that you can forget at least some of what you were thinking when you drafted. The very worst time to revise a draft is right after you have finished it. At that moment you are the worst possible editor: You know too much about what you have written and are thereby constitutionally incapacitated from reading your essay as your readers will.

Some research at Carnegie-Mellon University suggests why: A group of researchers created a passage on a technical subject and inserted into it problems of organization, sentence structure, clarity, and so on. They asked two groups of readers to read the passage and indicate where they had trouble understanding. One group, however, was given background reading in the subject of the passage before they read it. Which group was better able to identify those deliberately inserted problems? The readers *without* the background reading, of course: when the ones with the better knowledge hit a passage with errors, they were able to bring up from memory what they already knew. They didn't spot the errors in the writing because they were not relying on the writing to understand the ideas—they already understood. The ones without previous knowledge were much more effective in spotting flaws because they were much more attentive to the text. They had to be—without the background reading, the only way they could understand the material was to concentrate on the text.

At the moment you finish writing something, who knows more about it than you do? When you reread your own writing, you aren't really reading it; you're only reminding yourself of what you wanted to mean when you wrote it. That means two things:

1. The longer you can set aside something you have written before you revise it, the more you will have forgotten what you were thinking when you wrote it, and you will be able to

read what you have written more critically.

2. Even then, you will still know too much, and so you will need some ways to analyze, diagnose, and revise your own writing in a way that sidesteps your too-good memory of it.

A STRATEGY FOR ANALYZING AND REVISING

Here are some steps for rereading your essays in a reasonably objective way. These steps may seem formulaic and mechanical, but you need a way to diagnose your own prose so that you have some sense of how others will read it.

STEP 1: GET A SENSE OF THE WHOLE

This first step is intended to ensure that the beginning and end of your paper cohere with each other, that they "frame" your paper in an appropriate way.

1. Draw a line after the end of your introduction and just before the beginning of your conclusion.
2. Underline one sentence in *both* your introduction and conclusion that comes closest to expressing your main point, your claim, the thesis of your paper. In your introduction, that sentence is most likely to be the last one; in your conclusion, it might be anywhere.
3. Read the introduction and conclusion together, particularly comparing those two most important sentences. They should at least not contradict one another.

From an introduction:

During this unprecedented period, African-American artists shared in the process of creating a black urban identity through their depictions of a culture's experience.

From a conclusion:

While many were eager to slash the culture's ties to its "primitive" history, Armstrong and Motley created art which included elements of the community's history and which made this history a central part of African-American urban identity.

It is likely that the sentence in your conclusion will be more specific, more substantive, more thoughtful than the one in

your introduction. Your introduction may merely announce a general intention to write about some topic. If so, your conclusion is more likely to make a more important claim, generalization, or point about that topic. In the example above, the sentence from the introduction describes only the fairly general idea that artists contributed to a culture's identity by depicting its experience—an important idea, certainly, but one that your readers probably already hold. An essay that did no more than reiterate it would not be especially valuable. Contrast the sentence from the conclusion. Here, the writer is more specific in several important ways. First, she is specific about one element in African-American experience: its ties to its "primitive" history. She is specific about what the artists did: they included aspects of that history in their art. She also adds the suggestive information that some people opposed including "primitive" history in African-American culture ("While many were eager to slash the culture's ties . . ."). This controversy is potentially enriching for the essay because it may prompt the reader (and the writer) to analyze the subject from a very different perspective.

4. If you find that the sentence from your conclusion is more insightful than the one from your introduction, then you have to revise your introduction to make it seem that you had this sentence in mind all along (even though when you started drafting the paper you may have had no idea how you were going to end it). You can do this in one of two ways:
 - a. Insert at the end of your introduction some version of that sentence in your conclusion that comes closest to expressing your main point. You may have to revise the rest of the introduction to make it fit.
 - b. If you don't want to "give away" the point of your paper at the beginning, insert a sentence at the end of your introduction that at least anticipates your point by using some of its same language. For example:

As African-American artists such as Louis Armstrong and Archibald Motley, Jr. shared in the collective process of creating a black urban identity, they reflected their community's struggle to define the role of historical experience in modern culture.

Note that this sentence does not conclude that Armstrong and Motley did include "primitive" history in their art. But it does introduce some implicit questions that anticipate that conclusion: did these artists use their historical experience? If so, how? Those implicit questions set up the explicit point.

How do you choose between stating your main point at the beginning of the essay or waiting to state it at the end? If you think you are a skilled writer, the second choice—the "point-last" strategy—is a possibility. You must be certain, though, that the rest of the paper plausibly takes your reader to your conclusion. (We'll talk more about that in a minute.) Point-last writing, however, is always more difficult than point-first, and if you feel uncertain about your writing, or, more important, if you aren't interested in spending the extra time it takes to write good point-last prose, then you should state your main point explicitly at the end of your introduction. If you've stated your main point at the beginning of your essay, your reader won't lose track of your argument, won't lose the sense of where you are headed. More important, it will focus your attention on where you are headed. Don't worry that if you state your point first we will lose interest in your paper. If your point is interesting (or even if it's not), we will read on to see how you support it. (That, after all, is what you're paying us to do.)

There are, to be sure, some instructors, mostly but not exclusively in the humanities, who prefer point-last papers: papers that pose a problem in their introductions, then work toward a conclusion, demonstrating how the writer thought about the topic, wrestled with alternative answers, and finally discovered a solution. That kind of organization creates a dramatic tension that some instructors like, because they want to see the processes of your thinking.

The risk is that you might do exactly that! For nearly all of us, the process of our thinking is messy, inefficient, hard to follow. If you write a paper that in fact tracks what you thought about at 1 A.M., then 3 A.M., then 6 A.M., you're likely to write a messy, inefficient, and hard-to-follow paper. Few instructors want to see that. They want to see a coherent, ordered, analytical account of your thinking that may *seem* to be a narrative, but in fact is always an artful invention, something that requires writing skills of a high order.

So when you go through this first phase of your

analysis, you have to make a thoughtful choice about where you want to locate your point—in your introduction *and* your conclusion, or just in your conclusion, with an "anticipatory" point in your introduction. The default choice for both writer and reader is the first: point-first.

STEP 2: ANALYZING AND DIAGNOSING THE BODY OF THE PAPER

Now you need to determine whether the parts of your paper hang together to form a coherent argument and whether the parts are in an order that will seem to make sense to your reader.

1. Draw a line between every major section in your paper. A four- or five-page paper should have at least two and probably not more than three or four.
2. Now analyze and revise each section as you did your whole paper:
 - a. Put a slash mark after the introduction to each section. The introduction to a section may be only one sentence or it may be a complete paragraph. Each section needs a sentence that tells your readers that they have finished one segment of your argument and are moving on to another.
 - b. Put a slash mark before the conclusion to each major section. If your sections are short—only a couple of paragraphs or less—they might not each need a separate conclusion.
 - c. Identify the major point in each section. Just as your whole paper has to have a point, so should each section have a sentence that offers some generalization, some point, some claim that that section is intended to support.
 - d. If most of your points seem to be at the beginnings of your sections, fine. If most of them are at the ends of your sections as conclusions, you have to
 - e. Think hard about whether you want any particular section to be point-last. If you can think of no good reason, revise so that that section is point-first. If you decide that you want the section to be point-last, then you'll have to repeat for the section the

process we described for a point-last essay: You'll need to write an introductory sentence for the section that uses some of the key words that will appear in the point sentence that concludes the section. This principle simply reflects the needs of readers to know where they are and where they are going. Nothing confuses a reader more than moving from paragraph to paragraph with no sense of the logical progression of your argument.

- f. Try to explain to yourself why you put the parts of the paper in the order you did. If you arranged the parts of your paper in the order you did because that's the order in which they occurred to you, your readers are likely not to see any rationale for moving through your paper in the order they do.

- If you have three (or four, or whatever) reasons for something, why are the reasons in the order they are in? (By the way, beware of organization-by-number: "... for three reasons. First ... second. ... third. ..." If the *only* relationship you can demonstrate among your arguments is "first-second-third," your essay will probably be perceived as unsophisticated. Most significant arguments have substantive relationships: they are related not merely by number but by content.)
- If you have ordered the parts of your paper from cause-to-effect, why did you do that? Why not effect-to-cause?
- If you organized your paper to echo the organization of the text you are writing about, why have you done that? If you did, you risk having written a mere summary.
- If you organized your paper to match the terms of the assignment, is that what your instructor wanted, or did she want something more original from you?
- If you organized your paper around major topics in your assignment ("Compare and contrast Freud and Jung in terms of the role of society in the development of their theories")

did you write about, say, Freud first and Jung second simply because that was the order in the assignment?

There are so many principles of order that we cannot list them all here. We can only urge you to identify the one you chose and then to justify it as the best one from among the many possible.

STEP 3: REVISING THE INTRODUCTION AND CONCLUSION

After all this work on the body of the paper, you'll need to revise your introduction, but before we discuss introductions we want to talk about some local issues that can come into play while you're working on the body.

ON BLOCKING, DESPAIR, AND ACADEMIC WRITING TUTORS

At some point, you may find yourself staring at the screen or paper, utterly blocked. You can think of nothing to say that does not sound stupid. At that point, you might want to visit the Academic Writing Tutor working in the library or your residence hall. Every residence hall has at least one; all of them are trained to help you get over moments such as this; their hours are posted but not endless.

Before you see a tutor, though, be sure that you can describe what you have done, what not, and what parts of the task trouble you. The clearer you can be, the better advice you will get.

First, prepare an outline that shows the tutor where your paper stands. A sentence outline that lists main points is better than a topic outline, but any outline is better than none. It should show which parts you have drafted, which you are relatively sure of, and which are only guesses. If you are at the earliest stages of research and cannot formulate an outline, sketch your specific topic, either in a paragraph or two or as a list of topics you have begun to investigate.

Next, if you have a draft, print two double-spaced copies. One should be clean, ready for the tutor to mark up. The other you should mark up before you see the tutor. Do the following:

1. Draw a line between the introduction and the body of the paper and another between the end of the body of your paper and your conclusion. If the body is long enough to divide into two- or three-page sections, put lines between the sections.
2. Highlight the main point of your paper. If you have divided the paper into sections, highlight the main point of each section.

3. Circle the words near the end of the introduction that name the key concepts you will develop as themes in the rest of the paper. Then circle those words and words similar to them throughout.
4. If you have divided your paper into sections, repeat step 3 for each section.
5. Mark in the margins any problem areas where drafting was particularly difficult or where you are dissatisfied with what you've done.

Be sure to take your assignment sheet and anything else you have in writing from your instructor. The tutor can't help you solve every problem, but there are times when the opportunity simply to talk out loud about your problem will help.

Before you leave, get a plan of action *in writing*. Many students discover that while they are talking to a tutor, they think they understand what to do next, but that plan evaporates a few hours later when they sit down to work. Before you leave the tutor, write a plan of specific ways to improve your paper. If the tutor does not recommend specific actions, ask. You have the right to a plan that you can understand and follow.

SOME SPECIFIC ADVICE ABOUT LOCAL MATTERS

There are several local matters that you ought to look for in your early drafts.

MAKING YOUR EVIDENCE PERSPICUOUS

The most common evidence you will offer to support your claims will be quotations from the texts you read and references to passages in them. Without such evidence, your claims are merely statements of opinion. As we said, you are entitled to your opinions but you're not entitled to having your readers agree with them. In fact, your readers generally will not highly value your opinions unless you provide some evidence to support them. When you provide evidence, you turn your opinions into arguments.

But before readers can value your claim as supported with evidence, they must first understand how your evidence *counts* as evidence for that claim. No flaw more afflicts the writing of first year students than to make some sort of claim, offer a quotation from the text, and *assume* that the reader understands how the quotations speaks to the claim. Here is an example:

Lincoln believed that the Founders would have supported the North, because as he said, this country was "dedicated to the proposition that

all men are created equal."

The writer may be correct that Lincoln believed that the Founders would have supported the North, but what in that quotation would cause a reader to agree? In other words, how does the quotation count as evidence for the claim? The evidence says something about the views of the Founders in 1776. How does that support a claim about what the Founders would think about 1863? When pressed, the writer explained, "Since the Founders dedicated the country to the proposition that all men are created equal, and Lincoln freed the slaves because he thought they were created equal, then he must have thought that he and the Founders agreed, so they would have supported the North. *It's obvious.*"

Well, it's not. After it has been explained, it may or may not be persuasive (after all, the author of "all men are created equal" was himself a slaveholder). But it isn't obvious. Quotations rarely speak for themselves; most have to be "unpacked." If you offer a quotation without interpreting it, your reader will likely have trouble understanding how the quotation, as evidence, supports your claim. If you string together several such "unpacked" quotations, your paper will seem to be a pastiche, suggesting that your data never passed through the critical analysis of a working mind.

Whenever you support a claim with numbers, charts, pictures, and especially quotations—whatever looks like primary data—do not assume that what you see is what your readers will get. Spell out for them how it is that the data counts as evidence for your claim. For a quotation, a good principle is to use a few of its key words just before or after it. Something like this:

Lincoln believed that the Founders would have supported the North because they would have supported his attempt to move the slaves to a more equal position. He echoes the Founders' own language when he says that the country was "dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal."

QUALIFYING YOUR ARGUMENT

Some inexperienced writers think that the strongest and most persuasive kind of writing projects a voice of utter confidence, complete certainty, no room for doubt or the possibility of seeing things in a different way. That view could not be more mistaken. If communicating with your readers is like having a serious, mutually respectful conversation with them, then the last kind of person you want to talk with is someone who is **UTTERLY CERTAIN OF EVERYTHING WITH NO QUALIFICATIONS, RESERVATIONS, OR LIMITATIONS**. Two minutes with such a person is at least one too many. Compare these two passages:

- a. For more than a century now, every liberal has vehemently argued

against any kind of censorship of art and/or entertainment. And in the last twenty years, the courts and the legislatures of Western nations have found these arguments so persuasive that no one remembers any rebuttals to these arguments. Censorship has simply ceased to exist.

- b. For almost a century now, many liberals have argued against the censorship of art and/or entertainment, and in the last twenty years, courts and legislatures in most Western nations have found these arguments fairly persuasive. Few people now clearly remember what the rebuttals to these arguments were. Today, in the United States and other democracies, censorship has just about ceased to exist.

Twenty pages of the (a) prose would quickly grow wearisome. It is too strident, too flat-footed, completely unnuanced. But some would say that (b) is mealy-mouthed, too hedged with qualifiers. Here is a third version, with neither emphatics nor hedges:

- c. For a century now, liberals have been arguing against the censorship of art and/or entertainment, and in the last twenty years, courts and legislatures in Western nations have found these arguments so persuasive that few now remember what the rebuttals to these arguments were. Today, in the United States and other democracies, *overt censorship by the central government has largely ceased to exist.*

It is hard to give completely reliable advice about hedging and emphasizing because different writers have different opinions about it and different fields do it in different ways. But something most of us share is a sense of caution. (Notice that we said "most of us.")

Another kind of reservation you ought to make room for in your papers is plausibly contradictory evidence. No matter what position you take on a text, there will almost always be some evidence in it that someone can use as a basis to disagree with you.

Lincoln may have been willing to let his readers associate the Founders with the North, but it is not clear that he actually believed that they would have supported the Union. He does not specifically say so. Although he describes what the founders did in the past ("Four score and seven years ago"), he does not say what they would do in the present.

The shrewd writer considers these kinds of objections before readers do, and may include the objections in the essay. Once you think you have constructed an argument that fully supports your claim, skim your reading again, specifically looking for evidence that might support a different conclusion. Then raise that evidence and counterclaim in order both to acknowledge and, if you can, rebut them. Even if you can't fully rebut them, you can suggest that the weight of evidence is still

on your side. Don't worry that including counterevidence will make your argument less persuasive. On the contrary. While there are exceptions, most academic readers are much more persuaded by writers who admit reservations than by writers who insist that they are absolutely correct.

The point here is to avoid the kind of flat-footed, unnuanced, unsophisticated certainty that characterizes the thinking of someone who does not recognize that things are usually more complex, less clear-cut, than most of us wish.

BACK TO STEP 3: REVISING THE INTRODUCTION AND CONCLUSION

If you are satisfied that you have made a claim, supported, and qualified it, and that the parts of your paper hang together, you are probably ready to write the final versions of your introduction and conclusion. These are important, because the introduction will create a "frame" through which your readers understand and interpret everything that follows. Your conclusion is your last opportunity to shape your reader's memory of your paper.

INTRODUCTIONS

We've already touched on your decision whether to state your point at the end of your introduction and in your conclusion, or whether to end your introduction with a kind of "anticipatory, jumping-off" point that only launches the reader into the body of the paper but does not reveal the full contours of your claim. There are advantages and disadvantages to both (see Step 1). Whichever strategy you choose, you have to use your introduction to lead up to either your main point sentence or to that launching-point sentence.

The most important role of your introduction is to give a brief statement about the question or problem that you are answering or solving. You do this by suggesting something that is puzzling, not entirely understood, perhaps overlooked, not noticed, undervalued. The intention is to make your reader feel that you have answered a question that is worth asking, that you have seen something that helps make sense out of a reading. Here are two introductions the first typical, the second not. They both respond to an assignment asking students to discuss ways in which Tolstoy used the French language to critique social and cultural values in *War and Peace*.

- a. In *War and Peace*, Tolstoy portrays many aspects of Russian society. One of the most important and interesting of these is the role of the French language. Throughout the book, many characters speak French, although this is the language of their enemy. Later on in the book, the Russians are concerned about using French and begin to learn and use Russian. This very significant shift in the language of the characters indicates some of Tolstoy's views about the values

contained in Russian culture. By comparing the use of the French language throughout *War and Peace*, Tolstoy's views of culture can be examined.

- b. Throughout *War and Peace*, the French language is linked to a range of negative themes. In the opening scene, superficial characters at the soiree reveal their artificiality and insincerity through their ostentatious use of French. Those characters who are the most adept at French tend to be the most concerned with social appearances; those who speak Russian are usually associated with honesty and unselfishness. It is notable that those Russians who speak French incorrectly are good, straightforward, kindhearted souls, while those who smirk at their virtues speak flawless French. It is misleading, however, to conclude that there is a simple association between negative values and the French language. Although it may seem that French itself reveals a character's superficiality or viciousness, this is not always the case. Very often, Tolstoy uses French in conjunction with irony, paradox, or other literary techniques. The French language is not the main vehicle of Tolstoy's cultural criticism, rather, it is more like a parasite that lives off other devices, a virus that intensifies their effect.

The tone to avoid at all costs is the tone of that first one: "Well," it says, "you asked me to write about French in *War and Peace*, so I will. You said that Tolstoy uses French to criticize certain values, so I'll repeat that. You seem to think this matters, so I'll say that it is 'important,' 'interesting,' and 'very significant.' Then I'll cite lots of places in the text where Tolstoy uses French to criticize values. Isn't that what you want?" No. Mostly, this is not what they want. The first introduction makes the paper seem merely a report on a topic: the paper will report on the places where the writer found Tolstoy using French to criticize values. There is no sense of the writer having thought much about *War and Peace* because the paper seems to answer no question, resolve no puzzle, solve no problem. In the second introduction, the writer suggests that there is something difficult to understand about the way Tolstoy uses French in *War and Peace*. This writer suggests that what appears to be true about the link between French and values may be a misunderstanding of the text. Where the first writer positions her paper as a list of citations from the text, the second writer positions her paper as an effort to enhance our understanding.

For the opening sentence in your introduction, you might try to find a quotation in the text that you can say inspired your question or raises your problem, a quotation that you can balance with one at the end of your conclusion.

CONCLUSIONS

Your conclusion is the easiest to revise, because you will probably have already written a conclusion that makes a good point. Most of us

write to discover, and it is at the end where we discover our most interesting ideas. We have to make sure our introductions cohere with our conclusions, but for the most part, our conclusions will be the richest, most complex part of our paper, because that is where we are prepared to do our richest and most complex thinking.

In addition to stating—or restating—the main point, usually as the first or second sentence of the conclusion, most writers want to go beyond it. They can do that in two ways:

- They can suggest the significance of their conclusion. They do that by suggesting the consequences of answering the question they asked, solving the problem they posed. In effect, they answer the question "So what?" Try that as a strategy for revision: State your main point, and then have someone ask, "So what?" If you can answer that question, you have identified the significance of your point. The following is a conclusion from a paper whose main point was that the character Kurtz in *Heart of Darkness* did not accomplish a "moral victory." But as you'll see, the writer ended the essay not only by restating this point but also by suggesting that this problem of Kurtz's morality has implications for another problem: the problem of whether *Heart of Darkness* is a racist text.

The contrast between Kurtz and Nietzsche's Superman has shown that Kurtz did not achieve any kind of "moral victory" by being true to his nature. On the contrary, Conrad has shown in Kurtz the moral defeat not only of one individual but of European civilization in general. One implication of this defeat stems from the fact that it is highlighted by the contrast between the hypocrisy of the Europeans and the utter honesty of the natives. Those who have denounced *Heart of Darkness* as racist seem to assume that Conrad denigrates the native Africans. The question of Conrad's racism becomes much more complicated if we understand that the savages of the novel stand in contrast to the object of the book's true condemnation. The honesty of the so-called savages only intensifies Conrad's moral condemnation of his own European culture.

- Another way of thinking about your conclusion is to try to say what further questions your paper raises—what would you like to know more about, what puzzle remains—better yet, what *bigger* puzzle do you now have?

The last thing you might add to your conclusion is a quotation from the text that brings your paper to a graceful close. The quotation should be striking, gnomic, epigrammatic—a quotation that is especially graceful or figurative.

THE SECOND TO LAST TASK: A TITLE

After you've revised the text and, especially, after you've reworked both your introduction and your conclusion, you're ready to write (or revise) your title. The least useful kind of title is one that anyone knowing your assignment could predict from the language of the assignment. If the assignment is, "Discuss the logical structure of the Declaration of Independence, particularly those assumptions on which Jefferson based his argument," do not create the title:

The Assumptions behind the Logic
of the Declaration of Independence

A useful title tells the reader what the central conceptual elements in your paper are. Those elements are most likely to appear in your conclusion. So go to your conclusion, particularly to the main point sentence in your conclusion, and circle six or seven key words, particularly words that did not appear in the assignment. Now out of those words, construct a two-part title on the model of

XXXXXXXXXX:
YYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYY

Something like:

Logic in the Declaration:
Timeless Ideals and Immediate Realities

The first line ends in a colon, the second line can be longer or shorter than the first. The reason for writing a two-part title is that if you don't get it right in the first part, you might get it right in the second. Avoid using words in your title if those words are not prominent in your paper. It's fine to be clever with a title if, while being clever, you also capture some of the key words from your paper. It's generally a bad idea to be clever if it means that you fail to give your reader any of the central ideas she'll need to make sense of your paper.

THE LAST TASK

Your last task may seem trivial, but for a good many of your teachers, it will determine whether they judge you to be careful, thoughtful, and mature, or sloppy, careless, and thoughtless: You have to proofread your paper to be certain that you have no spelling errors, your grammar is acceptable, the sentences are reasonably punctuated, and your paper is in the right format.

At least run your spell-checker. Better, put your paper aside for an hour, then return to it to catch the kinds of errors that spell-checkers

can't find: wrong words, sentence fragments, mish-mashes of sentences and paragraphs you created when you were deleting, cutting, and pasting. Do your subjects and verbs agree? If you are working on a computer, do global searches for these words to be certain that you are using them correctly: *there, their, they're; its, it's; your, you're*.

Have your roommate read your paper. It is not dishonest to ask a friend to read over a paper to catch typos and so on. We all do it.

Before you run off your last draft, make sure of all this:

1. Most instructors will not accept handwritten papers. If you're using a word-processor, pick a standard font, preferably a "serif" type such as the one you are reading. Unless you're willing to bear unpleasant consequences, you shouldn't choose this moment to express your creativity by using one of the ornate or bizarre fonts on your computer. Pick a standard font like Times or Palatino.
2. Use a 12 point font.
3. Be sure your printer or typewriter will produce a clear, dark, black type. Don't turn in a paper printed in green, red, or blue. Black and only black.
4. Double-space (except for block quotations; single space them).
5. Margins all the way around of no more than 1.25 inches.
6. Number your pages, upper-right-hand corner.
7. Put your name at the top of every page.
8. Unless you have other instructions, on the first page, in the upper right hand corner, put your name, the date, your class section if any, and the name of your instructor:

John Smith
2/14/96
Section 9
Mr. Williams

9. After you print it out, staple or paperclip the pages together.

Be sure that you have made two copies of your paper, and that you have backed up your file on a separate floppy.

THE PITFALL TO AVOID AT ALL COSTS

There is a last matter to address. We perhaps should have addressed it earlier, because it will be as you draft that you risk doing the worst thing that can happen to a writer: In the heat of drafting, you are confidently plowing through your notes, finding good things to say, filling up the page or screen with lots of good words. *And those words belong to someone else.*

Plagiarism is a topic that embarrasses everyone, except, perhaps, the successful plagiarist. But every researcher needs to give it serious thought. Some acts of plagiarism are deliberate. No one needs help to know that it is wrong to buy a term paper, copy a paper from a fraternity's files, or use large chunks of an article as though the words were your own. But most plagiarism is inadvertent, because the writer was not careful when taking notes, because he does not understand what plagiarism is, or because he is not conscious of what he is doing.

You plagiarize when, intentionally or not, you use someone else's words or ideas but fail to credit that person. You plagiarize even when you do credit the author but use his exact words without so indicating with quotation marks or block indentation. You also plagiarize when you use words so close to those in your source, that if your work were placed next to the source, it would be obvious that you could not have written what you did without the source at your elbow. When accused of plagiarism, some writers claim, "I must have somehow memorized the passage. When I wrote it, I certainly thought it was my own." That excuse convinces very few.

When you want to use the exact words you find in a source, stop and think. Then,

- type a quotation mark before and after, or create a block quotation.
- record the words *exactly* as they are in the source (if you change anything use square brackets and ellipses to indicate changes).
- cite the source.

Those are the first three principles of using the words of others: unambiguously indicate where the words of your source begin and end, get the words right (or indicate changes), and cite the source. Omit the first or last step and, intentionally or not, you plagiarize. You also plagiarize when you use someone else's ideas and you do not credit that person.

It is trickier to define plagiarism when you summarize and paraphrase. They are not the same, but they blend so seamlessly that you may not even be aware when you are drifting from summary into

paraphrase, then across the line into plagiarism. No matter your intention, close paraphrase may count as plagiarism, even when you cite the source.

For example, this next paragraph plagiarizes the last one, because it paraphrases it so closely:

It is harder to describe plagiarism when summary and paraphrase are involved, because while they differ, their boundaries blur, and a writer may not know that she has crossed the boundary from summary to paraphrase and from paraphrase to plagiarism. Regardless of intention, a close paraphrase is plagiarism, even when the source is cited.

This is borderline plagiarism:

Because it is difficult to distinguish the border between summary and paraphrase, a writer can drift dangerously close to plagiarism without knowing it, even when the writer cites a source and never meant to plagiarize.

The words in both these versions track the original so closely that any reader would recognize that the writer could have written them only while *simultaneously* reading the original. Here is a summary of that paragraph, just this side of the border:

According to Williams and McEnerney, writers sometimes plagiarize unconsciously because they think they are summarizing, when in fact they are closely paraphrasing, an act that counts as plagiarism even when done unintentionally and sources are cited (p. 207).

Here is a simple test for inadvertent plagiarism: Be conscious of where your eyes are as you put words on paper or on a screen. If your eyes are on your source at the same moment your fingers are flying across the keyboard, you risk doing something that weeks, months, even years later could result in your public humiliation. Whenever you use a source extensively, compare your page with the original. If you think someone could run her finger along your sentences and find synonyms or synonymous phrases for words in the original in roughly the same order, try again. You are least likely to plagiarize inadvertently if as you write, you keep your eyes not on your source, but on the screen or on your own page, and you report what your source has to say after those words have filtered through your own understanding of them.

We take plagiarism seriously because it is a kind of theft: By not acknowledging a source, the plagiarist steals some of the little reward that an academic community has to offer, the enhanced respect that a researcher spends a lifetime trying to earn. The plagiarist steals from his community of classmates by making the quality of their work seem worse by comparison and then perhaps steals again by taking one of the

few good grades reserved to reward those who do good work. By choosing not to learn the skills that research can teach him, the plagiarist not only compromises his own education but steals from the larger community that devotes its resources to training students to do reliable work later.

But plagiarism is worse than mere theft because, like theft among friends, it shreds the fabric of community. When intellectual thievery becomes common, the community grows suspicious, then distrustful, then cynical—*So who cares? everyone does it.* Members of the community then have to worry as much about not being tricked as about teaching and learning.

GOOD LUCK

Here at the end, we can say only that if you are like many students, no part of your education will prove more useful to you than your ability to write well and quickly. When we have asked graduates of the College what they value most about their education here, they most often mention three things: the ability to think critically, the ability to solve problems, and the ability to write well. We believe that these three things are part of the same thing.



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of Chicago

Edited by Philippe Desan